Thtick 'Em Up

By Barbara Lhota and Janet B. Milstein

CHARACTERS: ***TROY:*** *mid-20s, a mugger and* ***JANICE:*** *mid-20s, an angry commuter*

(Suddenly, Troy jumps out of the alley.)

JANICE: (Screams.) Ahhhhhh!

TROY: Shh, shh, shh!

JANICE: Don't shhh me! What is your problem? You shouldn't jump out of alleys in front of people.

TROY: I'm thorry. I'm thorry. I wasn't thrying to sare you, sare you - (Shaking his head.) scare you!

JANICE: OK. Fine. Apology accepted. (Mumbling to herself) Be patient. Do not blow up. Obviously from the state facility.

TROY: (Following.) Hey, I juth need to athk you thomething.

JANICE: Oh great. Look, I can tell you right now, you will not get my hard-earned cash. What's left of it anyhow. You looking for a handout? Go back to school. (She walks faster.)

TROY: (Running after her, following, whispering.) Give me your furth.

JANICE: (She stops and turns.) What?!

TROY: Give me your furth!

JANICE: My wh - what?!

TROY: Furth! Furth! You hearf me!

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INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: Thick Em' Up by Barbara Lhota and Janet B. Milstein

JANICE: Well, I may have "hearf" you, but I didn't understand you. Do you understand this? (Pretending to do sign language.) I do not understand furth. (Opening and closing hands toward him.)

TROY: Wewl, you know what I mean!

JANICE: No, I don't! Maybe if you'd take that ski mask off your face, idiot, you could. (Overenunciating.) Enunciate your words and I'd understand.

TROY: Your muh-ey! Your muh-ey!

JANICE: Muh-ey? Yeah. Muh-ey. OK!

TROY: I'm not k-kidding, lady! I want your muh-ey! (Holding out his hand in his pocket.) I have a kun in my focket!

JANICE: (Beat.) Uh-huh. Good for you.

TROY: No! (Points down to his pocket.) A kun, a kun, a gaga - gaaan!

JANICE: Gaaa - Gun? Are you trying to say you have a gun in your focket?!

TROY: Yeth!

JANICE: Are you trying to say. . . (loudly) are you trying to rob me?

TROY: Yeth!

JANICE: (Even louder.) Help! He wants my purse!

TROY: (Putting his finger to his lips.) Shhhhhhhhhhhhhth!!

JANICE: (Calling across the street.) Sir, oh sir, help! (To Troy who doesn't know what to do.) See, he sees me! (Looking across the street.) Heeeellllllp! (Beat.) Where are you going? Can't you see this man is . . . ? (To man across the street.) You suck, you. . . bad man!!!

TROY: You should be sare. I could take you in the alley.

JANICE: And do what?! Take my three dollars and two maxed out credit cards?

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TROY: Thwee? Dat's all?

JANICE: Yeah! And a box of feminine hmm-hmms. Which you cannot have! Those things cost an arm and a leg.

TROY: Are you thure you're not wying to me about the thwee bucks?

JANICE: You want to count it, you little defect?

TROY: Defect? Dat's not nithe. I have a kun. You should be sare.

JANICE: (Imitating him, making him sound whiney.) "You should be sare. You should be sare." I'm not sare!

TROY: (Grabbing her arm.) I'll take you in the alley if you keep theaming.

JANICE: I'm not theaming! And I'll cut your head off if you take one more step. How do you like that threat? (Annoyed.) Now, let go of my arm. Let go!

TROY: (He does.) I'm thorry.

JANICE: You should be. (Rubbing it.) That hurt my arm.

TROY: OK. God. But you're juth thapposth to give me your furth. And I'll go. I'll go.

JANICE: You know what, buddy, I'm sorry to disappoint you, but I'm keeping my purse. Hmm-hmms and all. You picked the wrong lady to rob tonight. OK? You know why? I don't care if I die. In fact, I don't think I will. I think it's more likely that you will die!

TROY: I don't have time for thith!

JANICE: Ohhhhhh, well, you may not, but I have time. I have plenty of time. You know why?

TROY: No.

JANICE: Because I was fired today. (Screaming at him.) Fired!

TROY: (Jumping.) You don't haf to theam everything.

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JANICE: I'll theam when I want to theam! You see, I don't have control. I'm not "good with authority." I "fly off the handIe." I have "poor anger-management skills." I don't get along with others. (Doing flaky imitation.) "I create a negative climate!"

TROY: (To himself.) I don't know what I'm doing wong.

JANICE: (Sighing.) So I get a little crazy one time and dent the kitchen wall of the Burnstein's with my head? That's why we have extra two by fours. That's why we have cement filler. (Screaming.) That's why we have white paint!

TROY: You dented a wawl with your head?

JANICE: Well, at least I'm not inept like you. You know you're a total disaster at this thing?

TROY: Disathter? What am I doing tho wong?

JANICE: What are you doing right is the question? It was obvious from the beginning that you'd never done this before.

TROY: It wath?

JANICE: Yes, for one, saying you're sorry for jumping out at me didn't help. No offense. But you have to sound a tiny bit confident to get action.

TROY: I did, I did! Didn't I?

JANICE: Are you kidding? And you got to look like you know what you're doing.

TROY: I did.

JANICE: Well, now, don't get insulted!

TROY: I'm not! I juth want to know what I did wong.

JANICE: Well. . . the ski mask is a dead giveaway.

TROY: Wheally?

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JANICE: Yeah. Take it off! Nobody wears a ski mask when they rob people anymore. It's just. . . out. Muggers know darn well that cops aren't going after one person who mugs someone for a couple of bucks. They're going after huge gangs - hell, drug dealers, terrorists, CEOs. They don't have time for schmucks like you.

TROY: Yeah?

JANICE: SO the ski mask just makes you look really unprofessional and you're probably all hot under it. It's safe to take it off. Go ahead.

TROY: You think? (She nods.) I do feewl a wittle fainty. (He takes it off)

JANICE: That's better. And this gun threat of yours? Really dangerous. You're lucky I came by. In this neighborhood, somebody else might have taken one look at you and your little "kun in your focket" and pulled out an Uzi and blown your head off. (Doing imitation.)

TROY: (Cringes.) You're whight.

JANICE: And not to get into what I imagine is probably a sore subject there, but you do have a little. . . speech

TROY: I know. . .

JANICE: Well, it's an issue! You can't mug people if they can't understand you.

TROY: Well, it's not dat bad when I'm not nervouth. You underthood me.

JANICE: Eventually. But there was a major communication block with purse, money, and gun in your focket - pocket. You know what I mean? These are important words to communicate during a mugging.

TROY: Yeah, yeah. Twue. But I've been woo king on my wisp thing for yearth now. What am I thuppothed to do?

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JANICE: Keep practicing. (Looking at him.) You know you look very familiar now that I look at you. That lisp of yours reminds me of this dweeby kid I had a crush on back in grade school. I used to pick on him so bad because he was a little skinny, short guy, but when we were in gym class he sweat like a pi . . . oh my . . . Troy F-f-franklin?!

TROY: Janithe Afterbirth?!

JANICE: Alberts, Alberts! Oh my God! So how are you?

TROY: Well. . . not so good as you can thee. Actually, I only rethorted to this because of my thon.

JANICE: You have a son?

TROY: Yeth.

JANICE: SO you got married?

TROY: Yeth.

JANICE: (Disappointed.) Oh.

TROY: Yeah, but we're divorth.

JANICE: (Interested.) Oh. (Trying to cover.) Oh, that's too bad.

TROY: Yeah. We got mawied whight out of high school. It was too early. I wanted tho me one with a wittle more sthability. Bethides, I don't wheally think she liked me.

JANICE: How could she not like you? You're so sweet.

TROY: Thank you. Are you mawied?

JANICE: No.

TROY: (Happy to hear this.) Oh. Well, it'th alwayth better to wait. You'll find thomeone.

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JANICE: Yeah. If I want him. It's good being single. So what have you been up to job-wise?

TROY: Well, I thudied to be a twavel wep at this little speciality thool and I got a job whight away, and was working as a customer service wep for this small travel agency, booking tickets. Nobody said they couldn't understand me, but then this recession hit.

JANICE: Oh boy, don't you know it. Who wouldn't resort to mugging people?

TROY: It's wheally no excuse though. Really. I just wanted to get a little extra cash to pay for this electronic game little Carl wanted for Chrithmath tho bad. I juth thought if I could peacefully wob one nithe lady who was wobbable and had a wad of cash, I could get him thome stuff.

JANICE: Yeah. Hey, you thought I looked nice? Robbable?

TROY: Yeah. Real nice. Real Robbable.

JANICE: God. Thanks. That's really nice to hear.

TROY: You know, I wheally don't understand this anger management problem this boss says you have. You seem really in control and sane.

JANICE: By the way I'm sorry I threatened to cut your head off earlier.

TROY: Hey, like you said, it happens. I'm Glad I decided to stick you up tonight, even though you didn't understand a word of it.

JANICE: Yeah, well, I'm glad I had you take off your mask.

TROY: Yeah, you too. (She nods.) I mean, I'm glad I took it off too.

JANICE: SO. (Beat.) Dmm . . . Well. . . cool. I'll just see you around?

TROY: Wait. Dh, uh so what are you up to tonight, Janice? I have thome hot chocolate back at home. And a few old ugly plates you could definitely throw.

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JANICE: Yeah? Are you asking me to . . .

TROY: Well, maybe, I, I, I'm - if, if, if - but if not

JANICE: You know, I always thought that was so cute.

TROY: Thanks. (Looks down.) (She takes his arm.)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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